An apartment for two

Part 1

The manager was doing a crossword at the help desk when the woman came in.

The desk sat just outside his office, positioned so he could see the entrance without having to turn his head. Its surface was clean but worn, the edges rounded smooth by years of use. A neat stack of forms occupied one corner. Behind him, the office door was open. Filing cabinets lined the wall inside, their labels yellowed but legible. A printer sat idle, its light steady.

The door closed behind her with a soft sound.

She paused just inside, adjusting the strap of her bag on her shoulder. Not nervously — just the small correction people make after walking in from outside. She took in the lobby: two wooden chairs beneath a notice board, the water purifier near the entrance, its indicator light steady.

She walked toward the desk.

“Hi,” she said. “I was told to come here and ask about a specific apartment.”

The manager looked up from the crossword.

“Sure,” he said. “Which one?”

She thought for a moment.

“The cheaper one,” she said. “The one that’s only rented to couples.”

Recognition crossed his face — quiet, unremarkable.

“Yes,” he said. “I know which one you mean.”

She smiled, relieved.

“I wasn’t sure how it would be listed,” she said. “They said it doesn’t always show up.”

“It doesn’t,” he said. “People usually hear about it.”

Behind her, the man who had driven her stepped toward the water purifier. He unscrewed the cap of his bottle and held it under the spout. The machine dispensed water with a low, familiar sound that blended into the room.

She glanced back briefly, then leaned slightly toward the desk.

“He just drove me here,” she said quietly. “My partner couldn’t make it today.”

The manager nodded.

“That’s fine,” he said. “That happens.”

The driver capped the bottle and took a sip.

“I’ll just wait here,” he said to her, casually. “Take your time.”

“Thanks,” she said.

He moved to one side of the lobby and leaned lightly against the wall, checking his phone. Nothing had been decided yet.

The manager slid the crossword into a drawer and stood.

“It’s on the third floor,” he said. “Lower rent than the others.”

“Yes,” she said. “That’s the one.”

“If you’d like to see it,” he added, “we can take a look.”

She nodded.

“Yes, please.”

She stepped aside as he came out from behind the desk, and together they headed toward the stairwell. The driver remained where he was, bottle in hand, waiting.

Part 2

The stairwell was narrow but clean, the kind of clean that came from repetition rather than effort. The paint on the walls was a pale green, worn smooth where people had brushed past it over the years. The light fixtures were evenly spaced, each giving off the same dull glow, so that the stairs looked the same from one level to the next.

The manager went first, keys in his hand. They made a small, familiar sound as he climbed.

She followed a step behind, her hand trailing briefly along the railing before she let go.

“I’ll explain the details once we’re inside,” the manager said, as they reached the first landing. His tone was casual, almost reassuring, like someone promising instructions after a demonstration. “It’s easier that way.”

“That’s fine,” she said.

“It’s nothing complicated,” he added. “Just specific to that unit.”

They continued upward. Their footsteps echoed softly, then settled into the stairwell as if absorbed by the walls.

“It’s a one-bedroom apartment,” he said. “Smaller than most of the others in the building.”

“That’s okay,” she replied. “We’re not looking for anything big.”

He nodded, as though he had expected that answer.

“The rent is lower because of that,” he continued. “And because of the way it’s rented.”

She waited for him to elaborate, but he didn’t.

They reached the second landing. From here, the stairwell felt quieter, the sounds from the lower floors no longer carrying upward.

“It’s rented only to couples,” he said. “Never to a single person.”

She slowed slightly, then kept climbing.

“Yes,” she said. “That’s what we were told.”

“That’s the policy,” he said, simply.

She considered asking why, then decided against it. Policies were often easier to accept without explanation.

“There are a few procedural things attached to it,” he added. “Nothing out of the ordinary. Just part of how it’s managed.”

They reached the third floor. The hallway there was narrower than the others, and noticeably quieter. The sound of their steps seemed to fade almost immediately, as if the corridor didn’t carry noise the way the rest of the building did.

The manager stopped at the last door.

“We’ll go over everything inside,” he said.

He unlocked the door and stepped back, holding it open.

“After you.”

She took a breath she hadn’t realized she was holding and stepped inside.

Part 3

The apartment felt brighter than the stairwell.

Light came in through two windows facing the street, catching the dust in the air and making it briefly visible before it settled again. The walls were painted an even off-white, the kind that didn’t invite opinion. The floorboards were clean, their finish dulled just enough to suggest age without neglect.

She stepped in slowly.

The living room was modest but well-proportioned. There was nothing in it, yet it didn’t feel empty in the usual sense. The space seemed to anticipate furniture, as though it had learned where things would be placed and was waiting for them to return.

She turned once, taking it in.

“It feels… ready,” she said, half to herself.

The manager closed the door behind them but didn’t lock it. He stayed near the entrance, hands loosely folded around the keys.

“One bedroom,” he said. “Kitchen’s through there.”

She walked into the kitchen. It was narrow but clean, the counters unmarked, the cabinets opening smoothly. She opened one, then another, testing them without thinking. Everything worked the way it should.

She nodded.

“This is fine,” she said. “More than fine, actually.”

She moved into the bedroom next. It was quiet there, quieter than the rest of the apartment, as if the walls had learned to absorb sound. The closet door slid open without resistance. The window faced the same direction as the living room, letting in the same soft light.

She stood there for a moment longer than necessary.

When she returned to the living room, the manager had stepped to the counter separating the kitchen from the rest of the space. He set the keys down carefully, aligning them side by side, their edges parallel.

“There’s a policy for this unit,” he said. “I’ll go through it in order.”

She leaned lightly against the counter, attentive.

“First,” he said, “the apartment is registered for two occupants only.”

She nodded.

“You understand that, right?” he asked.

“Yes,” she said.

“Second,” he continued, sliding a form toward her, “both occupants must be listed. Two names. Two signatures.”

He paused.

“Clear so far?”

“Yes.”

“Third,” he said, “the apartment must be occupied accordingly.”

She frowned slightly.

“Accordingly?”

“For two,” he said. “As stated.”

He waited, watching her face, not searching for anything in particular—just giving her space to respond.

She nodded again.

“Okay.”

She glanced at the keys.

“And the rent?” she asked. “It’s lower than the others we saw.”

“That’s part of the policy,” he said.

“Because it’s only for couples?” she asked. “So it’s more stable? Less turnover?”

The manager considered this, just long enough to seem thoughtful.

“Couples tend to stay,” he said. “There’s less adjustment.”

She accepted that.

“That makes sense,” she said.

She looked around the apartment once more, slower this time.

“Yes,” she said. “I think this would work for us.”

The manager gathered the forms and slid them back into a neat stack.

“Alright,” he said. “We can finish the paperwork downstairs.”

She nodded.

As they left, she took one last look at the living room. For a moment, she had the faint impression that the space was familiar with her already, as if it had seen this pause before.

Then she followed the manager out, and the door closed softly behind them.

Part 4

They walked back down the stairs together.

Without the conversation, the stairwell felt narrower than before. The green walls seemed closer now, the light unchanged. Their footsteps overlapped for a moment, then separated again.

The manager went first. She followed.

When they reached the lobby, the driver was sitting on one of the two wooden chairs beneath the notice board. He had taken his hat off and placed it beside him on the seat, its brim resting against his knee. His jacket was unbuttoned now. He leaned back slightly, looking up toward the ceiling, his eyes half-closed.

He didn’t look uncomfortable. He didn’t look alert either.

She hesitated for a second, then smiled when he noticed her.

“All good?” he asked.

“I think so,” she said. “I like it.”

He nodded, relaxed.

“Take your time,” he said. “No rush.”

The manager walked past them to the help desk and took his place behind it. He pulled a folder from the stack and opened it, smoothing the first page with his hand.

“Alright,” he said. “Let’s get started.”

She stepped up to the desk and set her bag down. The forms were straightforward: name, contact details, employment information. She filled them in carefully.

The manager watched without hovering.

“We’ll need both names on the lease,” he said. “Two signatures.”

“Yes,” she said. “My partner can come by later.”

“That’s fine,” he said. “There’s no hurry.”

He slid another set of papers toward her.

“These explain the policy,” he said. “Nothing you haven’t already heard. Just standard wording.”

She glanced at the pages but didn’t read them closely.

“And the keys?” she asked.

The manager reached into the drawer beneath the desk and placed two identical keys on the surface between them.

“You’ll get both now,” he said. “You can bring the second signature when it’s convenient.”

“Okay,” she said.

He gathered the completed forms and stacked them neatly.

“You can move in as soon as you like,” he said. “Today?” she asked. “If you want,” he said. She looked back at the driver. “That works,” she said.

She stood quickly, perhaps a little too quickly, gathered her bag and papers, and opened the office door. It didn’t close fully behind her — she let it swing most of the way shut and kept moving.

She stopped near the wooden chairs.

The driver looked up as she approached.

“It works,” she said. “I like it.”

He nodded and stood immediately. “Good.”

He shifted his weight, straightening his jacket, smoothing the front of it with both hands. He picked his hat up from his lap but didn’t put it on yet, holding it loosely at his side.

She set her purse down on the empty chair and took a moment to organize herself. She adjusted the strap of her bag, checked that the zipper was closed, smoothed her jacket at the shoulders. She tucked a loose strand of hair back behind her ear.

“It’s smaller than I expected,” she said, lightly. “But in a good way.”

He listened, waiting. She picked her purse back up and glanced toward the door. “We can go,” she said.

He put his cap on, settling it into place with a small, practised motion. “Alright.” They walked toward the exit together.

Behind them, the office door remained closed. The help desk was quiet. The wooden chairs stayed where they were, exactly as before.

Part 5

They settled into the apartment gradually.

At first, everything required discussion. Where to put the shoes. Which cabinet should hold the plates. Whether the window in the bedroom should stay open at night. The conversations were casual, overlapping, easy to abandon halfway through.

“This side gets more light,” he said one morning, standing by the living room window.

“Then we’ll put the desk there,” she said.

They cooked together in the evenings, negotiating space in the narrow kitchen with small, practiced movements. Sometimes they ate standing at the counter. Sometimes on the floor. They laughed when they reached for the same drawer.

The apartment felt cooperative then. Sound stayed contained. The rooms seemed proportionate.

When one of them left briefly, the other barely noticed.

“I’m heading out,” he’d say.

“Okay,” she replied.

He always came back.

Over time, the conversations shortened.

Not from conflict. From repetition.

“Keys?”
“By the door.”

“Did you lock up?”
“Yes.”

Eventually, speech gave way to convenience.

Leaving now.
Okay.

The shift felt natural. Texts were efficient. Clear. They arrived quickly and required little response.

She noticed, after a while, that the apartment felt different when she was alone.

Not empty. Just uneven.

The living room felt too wide. The bedroom too narrow. She moved more than necessary, walking from room to room, adjusting lights, straightening things that didn’t need it. When he returned, the sensation faded without comment.

The building encouraged the routine.

Packages required both names. A delivery once paused when only she answered the door.

“I’ll come back,” the man said, apologetic, already stepping away.

Maintenance requests were rescheduled without explanation.

Texting became default.

Running late.
No problem.

Still at work.

Take your time.

She liked the predictability of it. The messages never contradicted each other. Never arrived unexpectedly.

The apartment stayed calm as long as the pattern held.

Part 6

The message came earlier than usual.

She had started cooking before sunset, planning to eat together for once. The phone buzzed while she was stirring a pot on the stove.

Running late.

She replied immediately.

Okay.

Dinner finished too soon. She turned the heat off and left the food covered on the counter.

An hour passed.

She sent another message.

Everything okay?

No reply.

She waited.

The apartment felt misaligned in a way she couldn’t ignore this time. The silence wasn’t empty—it felt provisional, as if something had been paused rather than removed.

At ten, she went to bed.

The other side stayed untouched.

In the morning, there was still no message.

She waited another day. Then another.

On the second evening, she packed a small bag.

She locked the apartment behind her.

The manager was in his office when she returned.

She stood across from him, the completed forms placed neatly on the desk between them.

“My partner won’t be coming,” she said.

He nodded, already reaching for a pen.

“That happens,” he said.

He signed where needed, then removed his glasses and set them down beside the papers. Without them, his face looked less defined, almost unfinished.

“I’ll need the keys,” he said.

She placed both on the desk.

Outside the office, a different driver waited.

He stood near the door, holding it open for her as she stepped out. She didn’t recognize him. His jacket was darker. His posture more formal.

As she passed through the doorway, the driver glanced back.

For a brief moment, he saw the manager standing inside the office, glasses in his hand, hanging loosely from his fingers.

The manager looked back at him.

Nothing was said.

The driver turned away.

They left.

Part 7

Three days later, the same driver returned.

He opened the gate first and stepped inside, holding it open as the man followed him into the building.

The electronic chime sounded as the door closed behind them.

“Good morning, sir,” the receptionist said from behind the help desk.

“Good morning,” the man replied.

He walked toward her, glancing briefly around the lobby — the two wooden chairs beneath the notice board, the water purifier near the entrance, the help desk positioned just outside the manager’s office.

Inside, the manager sat at his desk with a crossword spread open in front of him. Nearly every square was filled.

The man stopped at the desk.

“I was told to ask about a specific apartment,” he said. “The cheaper one. The one that’s only rented to couples.”

“Yes, sir,” the receptionist replied politely. “The manager can go over the details with you.”

She gestured toward the office.“He’s available.”The man crossed the short distance to the doorway.

“Excuse me,” he said. The manager looked up.“Yes,” he replied. The man stepped inside and closed the door behind him.

The receptionist reached beneath the desk, took hold of her bottle, and then stood. She walked to the water purifier and unscrewed the cap. The machine dispensed water with its low, familiar sound.

As she filled the bottle, the driver picked up the newspaper resting near the edge of the help desk. He walked to the wooden chairs.

He removed his coat, folded it once with care, and placed it on one chair. He set his hat neatly on top. Then he sat on the other chair and opened the newspaper, crossing one leg over the other.

The pages shifted softly.

The receptionist capped her bottle, took a brief sip, and returned to the help desk. She set the bottle down and resumed sorting the mail where she had left off.

Inside the office, the conversation remained low and even.

After a few minutes, the manager emerged first.

He removed his glasses as he stepped into the lobby, holding them loosely in one hand.

The driver glanced up from the newspaper.

The manager looked at him.

A brief pause passed between them.

Nothing was said.

Inside the office, the man checked his inside pocket, then the other, as if confirming the presence of something. He opened the door and stepped out, closing it gently behind him.

The manager was already near the stairwell.

“It’s on the third floor,” he said. “Lower rent than the others.”

“Yes,” the man replied. “That’s the one.”

“If you’d like to see it,” the manager added, placing one foot on the first stair, “we can take a look.”

The driver lowered the newspaper slightly.

“I’ll just wait here,” he said casually. “Take your time.”

“Thanks,” the man said.

Before stepping onto the stairs, he turned toward the help desk.

“Good morning,” he said.

The receptionist looked up.“Good morning, sir,” she replied politely. He paused briefly.

He had already greeted her when he entered. Neither of them mentioned it.

The manager continued upward. The man followed a step behind. They reached the first landing.

“I’ll explain the details once we’re inside,” the manager said. “It’s easier that way.”

Their footsteps echoed softly in the stairwell as they continued climbing.

In the lobby below, the newspaper pages turned. The mail was sorted into its proper stack. The crossword remained unfinished on the desk inside the office.